1.1 Reconstruction Under Andrew Johnson

Imagine you've been fighting with your friend. You both said and did terrible things, but you know it's time to forgive. How do you become friends again? That was the dilemma President Andrew Johnson faced after the Civil War.

MAIN IDEA President Johnson and Congress clashed over different goals for Reconstruction.

LEADING THE WAY

1865 was a rough year. The war had torn the nation in two, and the war's end did not repair this division. Lincoln was dead, and citizens mourned the loss of his thoughtful guidance and strong leadership. The new president, Andrew Johnson, faced the monumental challenge of rebuilding the United States politically, socially, and economically. Many decisions had to be made. How should the Confederate states be readmitted to the Union? Should Confederate leaders be punished? What role should free African Americans play in the country?

Johnson had been an unusual choice as Lincoln's vice president. He was a southerner from Tennessee who had served in Congress as a Democrat. But he was definitely pro-Union, a stance fueled by his dislike for wealthy southern planters. When Tennessee seceded, he remained in the U.S. Senate. Lincoln later appointed Johnson as military governor of Tennessee. During the Civil War, military governors worked to re-establish the governments of southern states conquered by the Union Army.

When the 1864 election rolled around, the Republicans chose Johnson to run as Lincoln's vice president based on his loyalty to the Union. But Johnson didn't support equal rights for African Americans. Like most southern whites, he was deeply prejudiced, which offended many Republicans.

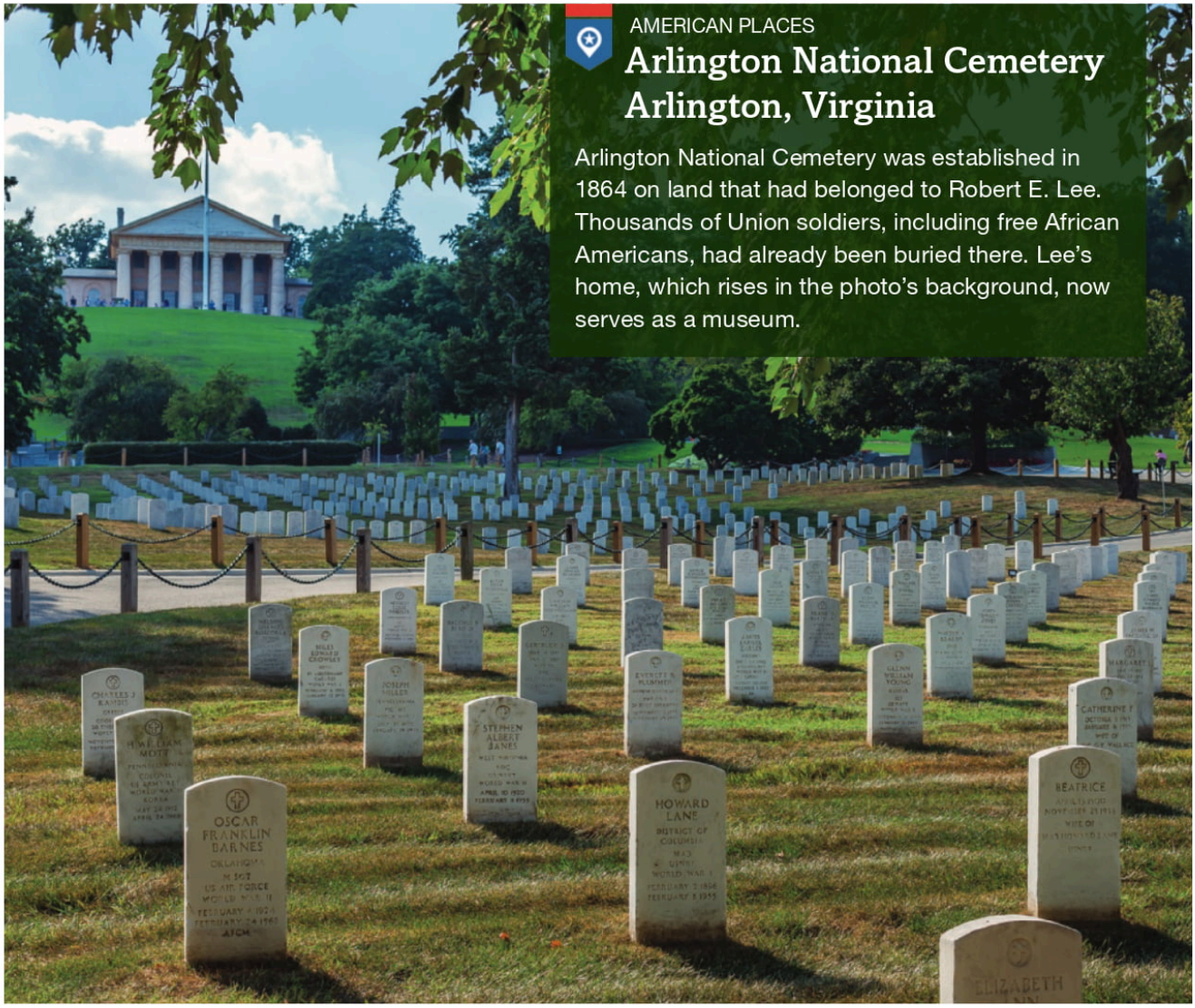
Among the first decisions Johnson made as president was to oversee Reconstruction himself, an approach called **Presidential Reconstruction**. Johnson's plan required Confederate states to ratify the 13th Amendment—which, as you may recall, abolished slavery—and create new governments with new constitutions before they could rejoin the Union.

Although he had repeatedly stated, "Treason is a crime, and crime must be punished," Johnson quickly pardoned, or legally forgave, most Confederates who took an oath of loyalty to the Union. The pardons restored their civil rights and protected their property from being seized. Only wealthy planters and high-ranking Confederate leaders had to apply individually for presidential pardons. Many in Congress felt Johnson's plans were too lenient, or forgiving. Congress wanted Confederates to pay for their actions.

THE FREEDMEN'S BUREAU

Johnson's perceived leniency toward the former rebels was not the only problem Republicans had with his plan. They were equally alarmed that Presidential Reconstruction did not provide a way for African-American men to vote, a right African Americans deeply desired. African Americans also wanted the right to own property. Without the protection of full citizenship and property rights, African Americans worried that white southerners would take away their newly won freedoms and economic opportunities.

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AMERICAN PLACES

Arlington National Cemetery Arlington, Virginia

Arlington National Cemetery was established in 1864 on land that had belonged to Robert E. Lee. Thousands of Union soldiers, including free African Americans, had already been buried there. Lee's home, which rises in the photo's background, now serves as a museum.

Republicans shared their concerns. In 1865, Congress created the Bureau of Refugees, Freedmen, and Abandoned Lands—more popularly known as the **Freedmen's Bureau**—to help the formerly enslaved, as well as impoverished white southerners. Congress appointed General Oliver Otis Howard to run the bureau. Army officers acting as bureau agents provided medicine, food, and clothing to newly freed African Americans and others displaced by the war. The officers also tried to settle former slaves on southern land that had been abandoned or seized during the war. Agents drew up labor contracts between landowners and African-American workers and created courts to settle conflicts between African Americans and whites.

Howard also saw education as a way to improve living conditions and economic opportunities for African Americans. The Freedmen's Bureau worked with northern aid groups to establish schools for the newly freed. By 1869, approximately 3,000 schools serving more than 150,000 students reported to the bureau. Yet in spite of this progress, neither President Johnson nor most whites were ready to grant full rights to African Americans. As a result, the Republicans in Congress decided to take control of Reconstruction.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What were the original aims of Reconstruction?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why might Johnson have chosen to be lenient toward many Confederates?
3. **SUMMARIZE** How did the Freedmen's Bureau affect newly freed African Americans?

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